

« Champions learn from...I'm not going to say their failures, but they learn from their losses. I knew he was going to learn from the French Open final and not make the same mistakes. That he was able to get over that so quickly and win here didn't surprise me at all – Alcaraz »

his mental health problems, stayed relatively calm and competed well, but his weak second serve and shaky volleying let him down. He won only 10 of 24 points at the net compared to 22 of 29 for Alcaraz. The knowledgeable, empathetic Centre Court spectators gave Rublev a standing ovation as he left the court.

Former world No. 9 and local favourite Cam Norrie offered little resistance to Alcaraz in their 6-2, 6-3, 6-3 quarterfinal. The indefatigable Norrie rode his bicycle to matches at The All England Club, but stamina was no factor in the one hour and 39 minutes on court. The Spanish maestro simply had too much firepower as he whacked 39 winners compared to 13 for his foe and more versatility, winning 22 of 31 at net.

IBM Watson made Sinner a 54 per cent favourite over Alcaraz in the Italian's first Wimbledon final. Curiously, the day before, Watson had Alcaraz as a 54 per cent favourite.

The championship match featured mercurial athleticism versus methodical power. Alcaraz took the first set 6-4 on a spectacular set point. Two amazing Alcaraz defensive gets kept him in the heavy-hitting rally. Then, he yanked Sinner outside the alley with a wicked forehand crosscourt and finished with a flicked backhand crosscourt winner into the open court.

Before the second set, McEnroe pointed out, "Because Alcaraz can do anything, he tries lower-percentage shots sometimes in critical

situations. Not every shot has to be highlight reel stuff." So true!

In the last three sets, Sinner increasingly anticipated and foiled Alcaraz's drop shots and, more importantly, dictated baseline exchanges. When Sinner held serve for a 3-1 lead in the second set, Patrick McEnroe said, "We're seeing more frustration from Alcaraz than we usually see and more outward emotion from Sinner than we've ever seen. They both know what's at stake."

The 6-4 second set also ended with a sensational point. Sinner trumped Alcaraz's excellent crosscourt forehand with a ferocious crosscourt winner.

The Big Two elevated each other's games, but Sinner was more consistent and took the third set, 6-4. When Sinner broke serve for 2-1 in the fourth set, Alcaraz looked confused and unsure of what to do. "Sometimes Alcaraz gets himself into trouble, but today it's a case of his opponent hitting him into trouble," said Patrick McEnroe.

During the changeover with Sinner leading 5-4 and about to serve for the championship, spectators rose to their feet and cheered. They wanted more — a fifth set like the two young superstars had in their memorable French Open final. But it was not to be. Sinner clinched the match with a 137-mph serve, his fastest of the match, that Alcaraz couldn't return.

Game, set, and championship: 4-6, 6-4, 6-4, 6-4 for Sinner.

On the other half of the draw, No. 5 seed Taylor Fritz enhanced his already impressive grass-court resume when he won June tune-up events at Stuttgart and Eastbourne. There was no rest for the weary, though: he faced a pair of 6'8" rocket servers in the opening rounds. With the roof closed and the heat stifling, Giovanni Mpetshi Perricard, a 21-year-old Frenchman, blasted serves over 150 mph, including a Wimbledon record 153. Fritz survived the onslaught, 6-7(6), 6-7(8), 6-4,



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